

CAUCASUS REPUBLICS



THE COUNTRIES of Georgia, Armenia, and Azerbaijan lie just within Asia, on a narrow plateau sandwiched between the Greater and Lesser Caucasus mountains. They are often collectively called Transcaucasia or the Caucasus Republics. To the west of the region lies the Black Sea, and to the east, the land-locked Caspian Sea. All three countries were part of the former Soviet Union and only gained their independence in 1991. Since the end of communist rule, growing ethnic and religious tensions have caused civil unrest throughout much of the region.



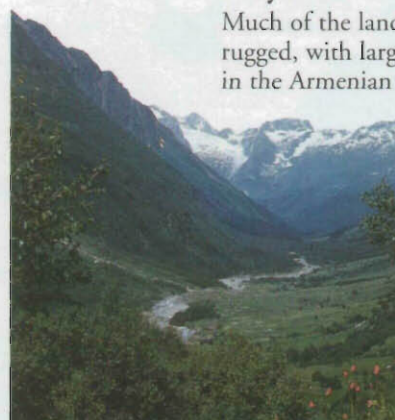
Regional climate

The varied landscape of this region gives rise to a wide range of climates. Georgia's Black Sea coast is warm and humid, while Armenia is generally dry with long, cold winters. The lowland areas of Azerbaijan have long, hot summers and cool winters. Winters in the mountains are bitterly cold.



Ararat Plains

Most of Armenia is a high plateau with large expanses of semi-desert. In the southwest, the land drops towards the River Aras, which forms the border with Turkey and drains most of Armenia. Known as the Ararat Plains, this fertile, sheltered strip is used for growing vegetables and vines.



Physical features

Much of the land is mountainous and rugged, with large expanses of semi-desert in the Armenian uplands. The Kura is the longest river, flowing 1,364 km (848 miles) from central Georgia, through the fertile lowlands of Azerbaijan to the Caspian Sea. The low Black Sea coastal area in western Georgia is lush and green. The area suffers earthquakes.

Greater Caucasus Mountains

The Greater Caucasus range stretches for about 1,200 km (745 miles) from the Black Sea to the Caspian Sea, effectively separating Europe from Asia. Rich in copper, iron, and lead, the mountains also shelter the Caucasus Republics from the icy winds that blow down from Russia in the north. The highest mountain is Mount El'brus at 5,633 m (18,481 ft), just over the Russian border.



Lake Sevan

Once valued for its pure waters and stunning setting, Armenia's Lake Sevan is at the centre of an ecological crisis. Tragically, irrigation and hydroelectric projects begun in the 1970s have caused the water level to drop by up to 16 m (52 ft).



Refugees of the war over Nagorno-Karabakh

People

More than 50 ethnic groups live in the Caucasus Republics. Most people speak the first language of their country, but retain their own customs and culture. Communist efforts to end ethnic differences failed, and racial tension is a major problem in the region.